AI Use Among Sociology Graduate Students

Graduate Program in Sociology, Purdue University · Summary of the fall 2026 graduate student survey
Data analysis and report generated with Claude Code (Anthropic), under the direction and review of the department

About the survey. An anonymous Qualtrics survey asked graduate students how often they used AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini) for specific tasks in **coursework** over the past year and whether they used or planned to use AI for their **AP or dissertation**, plus open-ended questions about how they decide when to use AI. **19 of 31 students responded (61%)**; 18 answered the coursework items and 16 the AP/dissertation items, and 16 wrote open-ended comments. Because the program is small, each respondent moves a bar by 5–8 percentage points; read the counts, not just the shares. Responses reflect who chose to answer and may differ from non-respondents.

Figure 1. AI use in coursework, past year

n = 18 respondents per item; tasks ordered by number reporting any use

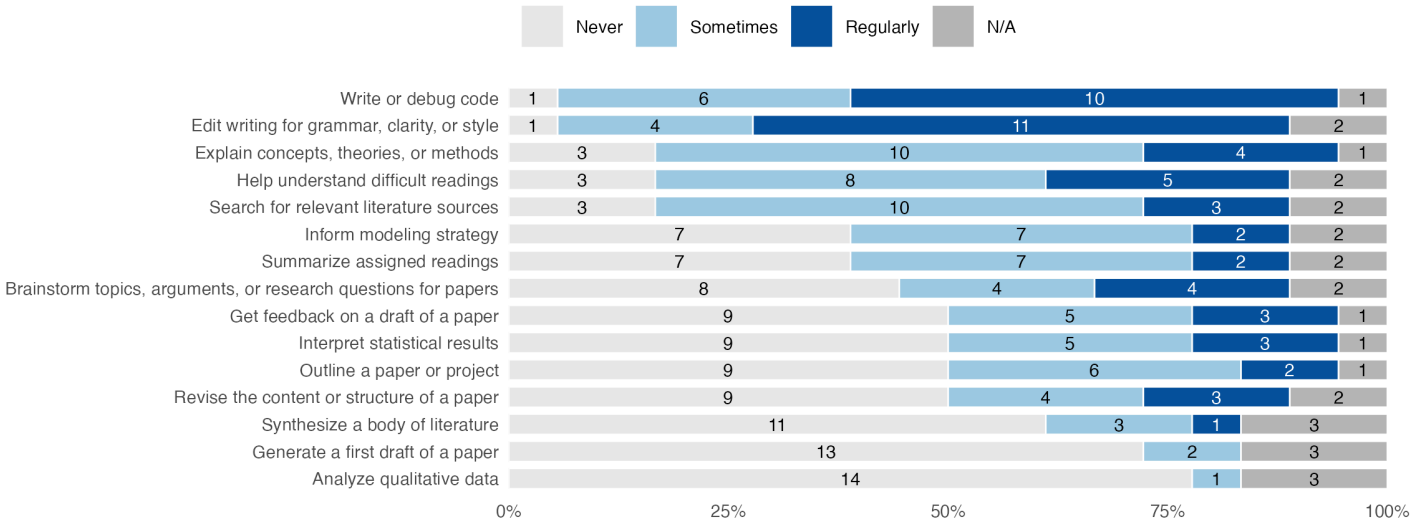
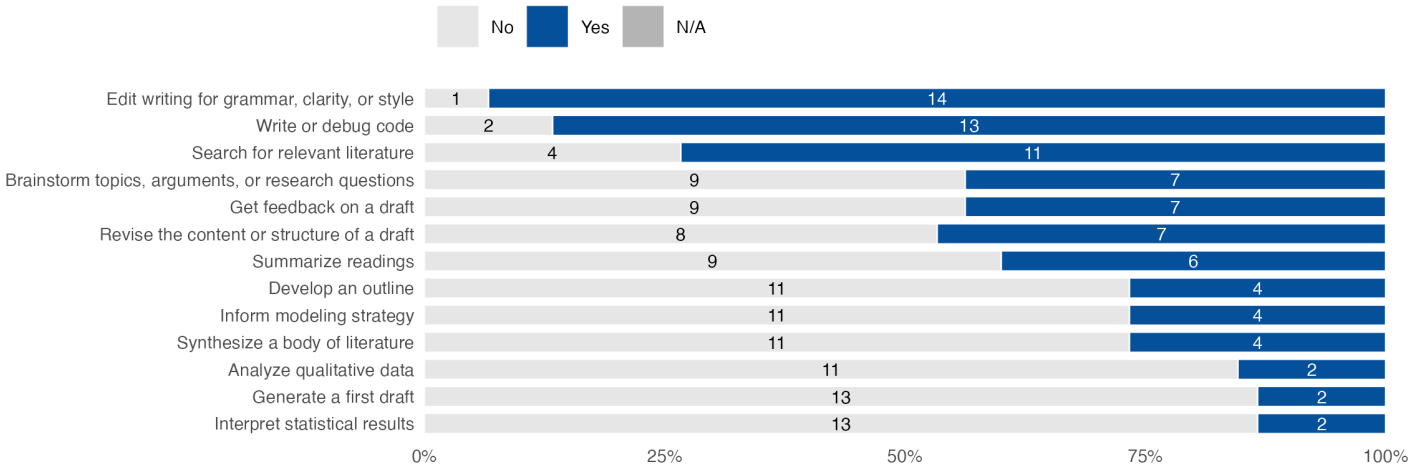


Figure 2. AI use planned or used for AP / dissertation

n = 13-16 respondents per item; tasks ordered by number answering yes



Key observations

- **Use is nearly universal but selective.** 17 of 18 respondents used AI for at least one coursework task; the typical respondent used it for about 7 of 15 tasks (range 0–15).
- **Editing and coding are the mainstream uses.** 16 of 18 used AI for code (10 regularly) and 15 of 18 for editing writing (11 regularly). Explaining concepts (14), understanding readings (13) and finding literature (13) follow.
- **Generating original content is rare.** Only 2 of 18 used AI to draft a paper in coursework, and 2 of 15 plan to for their AP/dissertation; 1 of 18 used it for qualitative analysis.
- **Dissertation plans mirror coursework.** 14 of 15 plan to use AI for editing, 13 of 15 for code, and 11 of 15 for literature searching. Interpreting statistical results is used by 8 of 18 in coursework but planned by only 2 of 15 for the AP/dissertation.

What students say about how they decide

Selected verbatim comments from the open-ended questions (identifying details removed). Themes are the analyst's reading of 16 respondents' comments.

1. AI as a support tool, with ideas and writing kept their own

> *"The line for me is basically I want my writing and ideas to be original to me, but I'm fine using AI to do things that people (myself or others) would take much more time to do (editing for grammar; collecting literature, etc.) so that I can concentrate my time and energy on the stuff that is original to me and my work."*

> *"I don't use AI to generate writing, but I will use it to polish the work."*

> *"I tend to think of AI like a "better" search engine -- I use it to find information that I would otherwise spend time searching the internet for, but I don't outsource other tasks to it."*

2. Checking AI's output and doubts about its quality

> *"I also try to verify citations, statistical results, and factual claims independently rather than assuming that AI is correct."*

> *"I don't think it produces good enough content to use effectively yet. I can't say I wouldn't be tempted to use it more if it produced better work."*

> *"Sometimes I use it to get feedback on my working drafts, but it tends to give affirmative comments more than giving sharp critiques."*

3. Privacy, language support, and the need for clear norms

> *"AI can be very useful for graduate work, especially for non-native English speakers. Writing and polishing academic English can take a substantial amount of time even when the underlying ideas are already clear"*

> *"always be aware of and show respect to the moral, legal, and ethical boundaries when using AI. For instance, not to upload interview transcripts or quantitative survey data to AI platform for analysis."*

> *"Clearer norms about appropriate AI use in research, writing, coding, and collaboration would also be helpful."*

> *"allowing students to use it at their own discretion, works for now."*

Quotes are verbatim from the de-identified data (spelling and punctuation unchanged). Some are excerpts that begin or end mid-sentence.